

Women in Aquaculture

Starting Your Aquaculture Business

A Step-by-Step Guide for Women Entrepreneurs

Women in Aquaculture (WiA)

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connecting, supporting and celebrating women across the aquaculture industry.

Is Entrepreneurship Right for You?

Starting an aquaculture business is exciting but demanding. Before diving in, consider your motivations, risk tolerance, financial situation, and support network. This guide walks you through the key steps.

Step 1: Research & Planning

- Identify your species and production system (pond, cage, RAS, seaweed)
 - Research your target market — local, regional, or export
 - Analyse competitors and identify your unique value proposition
 - Understand regulatory requirements — permits, environmental assessments
 - Visit existing operations and talk to experienced farmers
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Step 2: Business Plan

A solid business plan is essential. Key sections:

- **Executive summary** — your vision and value proposition
- **Market analysis** — demand, competition, pricing
- **Operations plan** — site, species, production targets, staffing
- **Financial projections** — startup costs, revenue forecasts, break-even
- **Risk management** — disease, weather, market fluctuations

Step 3: Securing Funding

- Government grants and subsidies for aquaculture development
 - Microfinance institutions specialising in agriculture
 - Impact investors focused on sustainable food systems
 - Women's entrepreneurship funds and competitions
 - Crowdfunding platforms for food and agriculture
 - Bank loans with collateral or guarantor arrangements
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Step 4: Setting Up Operations

- Secure your site — land/water rights, lease agreements, permits
 - Build infrastructure — ponds, cages, hatchery, processing
 - Source quality seed/fingerlings from certified suppliers
 - Establish feed supply and water management systems
 - Hire and train staff — prioritise local employment
 - Set up record-keeping for production, finance, compliance
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Step 5: Marketing & Sales

- Build relationships with local buyers, restaurants, distributors
- Consider direct-to-consumer sales via markets or online
- Obtain quality certifications (ASC, BAP, organic)
- Tell your story — consumers value traceability and sustainability
- Join industry associations for networking and market intelligence